Asian Englishes
World Englishes

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Overview

1. World Englishes
2. Variation in the Inner Circle
3. Speakers and Labels
4. Asian Englishes
5. Indian English
6. Singapore English
7. Hong Kong English
8. Philippine English
9. Japanese and Korean English
10. The Future

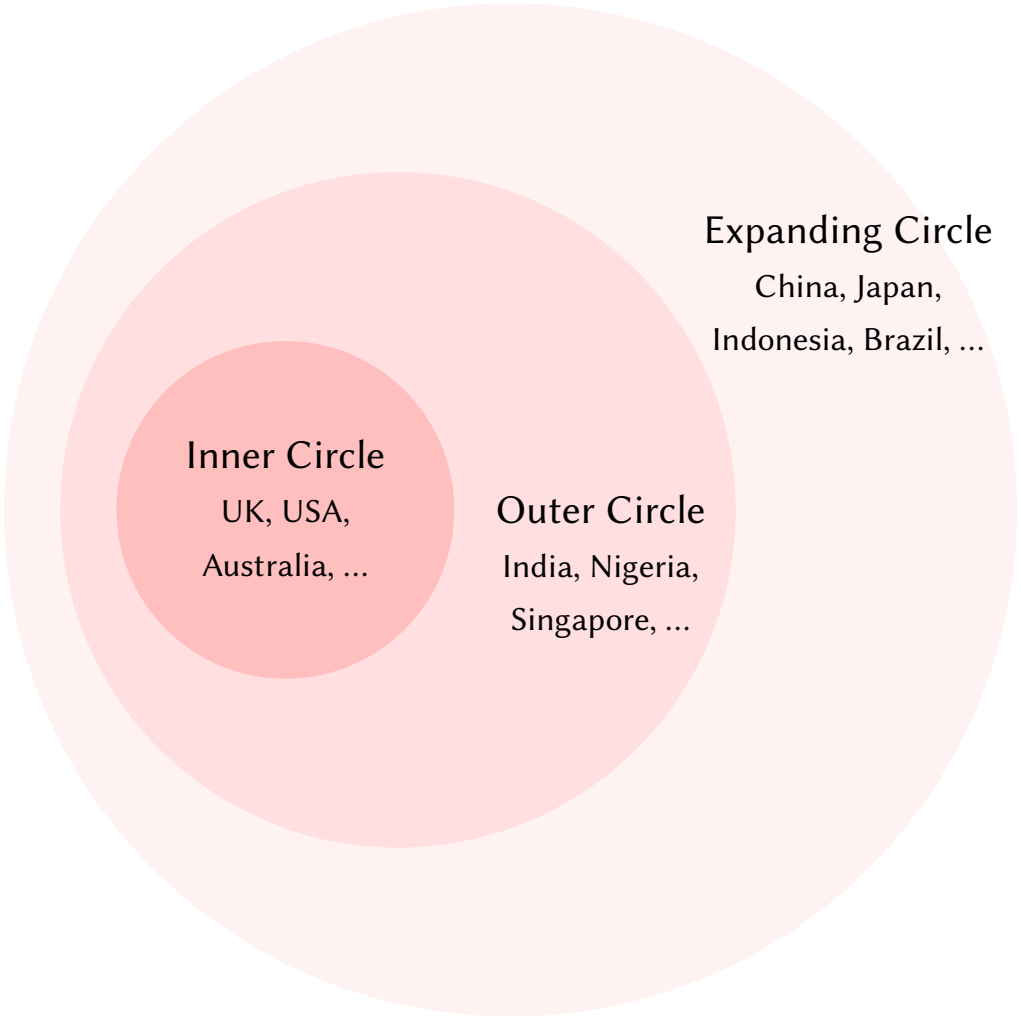
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World Englishes

- The **varieties** of English used around the world
- English as a global **lingua franca**, and English made **local**
- British, Indian, Chinese, Nigerian English ...

Kachru's Three Circles of English



After Kachru (1985)

The Three Circles

	English is ...	for example
inner	the main language; the "standard"	UK, USA, Australia
outer	a second, official language	India, Nigeria, Singapore
expanding	a foreign language	China, Japan, Brazil

- Outer: a colonial legacy, nativized varieties, much multilingualism (more speakers than the inner circle)
- Expanding: no colonial legacy, no official role, but the most speakers
- Singapore fits almost every inner-circle criterion except origin

Who Speaks English?

millions	speakers	first language	population
United States	299.3	244.1	312.1
India	269.8	1.3	1,400.0
Nigeria	125.0	20.0	206.2
Pakistan	108.0	<0.1	220.9
Philippines	70.1	<0.1	110.0
United Kingdom	63.7	59.3	64.8
Germany	45.9	0.8	82.3
Egypt	38.8	—	111.0
Canada	30.5	20.2	37.1
Australia	23.2	18.3	25.4
Singapore	2.7	1.7	3.6

After the USA, India has the most English speakers, over 99% of them as an additional language; Nigeria, Pakistan and the Philippines each have more than the UK.
Wikipedia, accessed 2026-10-08; figures are from different years

Quirk vs. Kachru

	Quirk (1985): uniformity	Kachru (1985): pluralism
standard	one, for intelligibility	many: diversity is real
teaching	inner-circle norms	validate local varieties
ownership	the inner circle	all its users
“errors”	a risk of misunderstanding	a deficit model to reject

“We need one standard English for international communication” vs “English belongs to all its users, not just its historical native speakers”

Four False Assumptions (after Kachru)

the assumption	the counterpoint
there is one homogeneous standard	inner-circle English varies too
outer-circle English is deficient	it is a legitimate local adaptation
teach inner-circle norms only	teach the local reality
inner-circle norms ensure intelligibility	intelligibility is mutual, and depends on context

A paraphrase of the argument in Kachru (1985)

Innovation, Deviation or Mistake?

innovation	creative use, often denied to non-inner speakers *timepass*, *skinship*, *add oil*
deviation	differs from some other variety's norm *He is knowing the answer.*
mistake	a learner's error, not a community's norm *He knowed the answer.*

Different varieties are held to different standards (Kachru, 1985). But regularized past tenses like *knowed* are systematic in some Appalachian and African American speech: so whose mistake is it?

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Three Standards: BrE, AmE, AusE

extended meanings	*corn*, *robin*
new words	*buttle* “to act as a butler”
borrowings	*moccasin*, *squash*, *toboggan*
later technology	*windshield* (US) vs *windscreen* (UK)

Vocabulary is the most noticeable difference; pronunciation differs too, and each region has its own dialects

Australian English Loves a Clipping

barbie	barbecue	*Snowy*	someone with white hair
uni	university	*Bluey*	a red-head
sanger	sandwich	*Bondie*	Bond (me)
relly	relative	*chuck a U-ey*	make a U-turn

Also loans from Aboriginal languages: *kangaroo*, *boomerang*

American and British Grammar Differ

	US	UK
verbs	*He already ate.*	*He has already eaten.*
nouns	*The team is winning.*	*The team are winning.*
adverbs	*He runs real fast.*	*He runs really fast.*
adjectives	*How big of a room is it?*	*How big a room is it?*
prepositions	*I went on the weekend.*	*I went at the weekend.*

Trudgill and Hannah (2002)

Prestige Hierarchies Everywhere

Australian English *Strine*	once "broad", "lazy"; now a national standard
AAVE *Ebonics*	rule-governed: copula absence, habitual *be*
Appalachian, Southern US	a-prefixing *He's a-running*, double modals *He might could do it*
Scouse, Geordie, Glaswegian	local prestige, little institutional prestige

The inner circle is not a uniform standard: all Englishes have prestige hierarchies, with **overt** and **covert** prestige (Burridge and Mulder, 1999; Rickford, 1999; Lippi-Green, 2012)

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What's Wrong with "Native Speaker"?

- Treats **monolingualism** as normal
- Overrates the order of acquisition
- Makes Anglo speakers the reference point, and power one-way
- Encourages a simple view of errors

What does it say about you as speakers of English?

Alternatives

Rampton (1990): **expertise** instead	
+	learned, not innate; relative, partial, contestable
—	"non-expert" is still a value judgement

Jenkins (2000): MES, BES, NBES	
MES	monolingual English speaker
BES	bilingual English speaker
NBES	non-bilingual English speaker

Both look at a speaker's whole **repertoire**, not native vs non-native

Names Are Not Neutral

variety	label	connotation
Indian English	*Hinglish*	code-mixing, youth culture; can stereotype
Singapore English	*Singlish*	officially a problem; locally, solidarity
Hong Kong English	*Kongish*	playful code-mixing; local, online
Japanese English	*Engrish*	from outside; mocking, racist

Linguists say *Colloquial Singapore English*, *Japanese English*, *wasei-eigo*. Labels index attitudes, power and ownership

Activity: How Would You Label Yourselves?

- NS / NNS? MES / BES / NBES? Something else?
- How do the labels affect
  - how confident you feel speaking English?
  - how you judge other people's English?
- Who gets to name a variety: the state, teachers, speakers, outsiders?

  - How does the name affect its prestige and legitimacy?

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Schneider's Dynamic Model

1	foundation	English arrives
2	exonormative stabilization	the norm comes from outside
3	nativization	local forms spread: India, HK, Philippines
4	endonormative stabilization	the local norm is accepted: Singapore
5	differentiation	new internal dialects

A path rather than static circles, shaped by settlers' and locals' identities; it explains why Singapore looks inner-circle (Schneider, 2007)

What Asian Englishes Share

phonology	local accents and stress: Indian retroflexes
syntax	local influence: Singapore drops articles
lexicon	borrowings: Malaysian *chop* “seal, stamp”
use	extensive code-switching

Codification brings acceptance, prestige and a classroom model, but local varieties are still seen as interlanguages, measured against native-speaker competence

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Indian English

pronunciation	variably rhotic (especially in the south); different vowels in *bat*, *bad*, *bed*
vocabulary	*prepone* “reschedule earlier”, *godown* “warehouse”
grammar	stative progressive: *He is knowing the answer.* *doubt* “question”: *I have a doubt in maths.*

Shaped by India’s many languages; used in government, education, business and media, and a bridge in a multilingual society

Indian English Vocabulary

semantic shifts	
pass out	graduate
out of station	out of town
revert	reply (also Singapore, Malaysia)
local coinages	
hill station	mountain resort
timepass	leisure activity

Some Indian words have gone into general English: *bungalow* (Hindi *bangla*), *jungle* (*jangal*)

Indian English in Use

- *Can you prepone the meeting to tomorrow?*
- *I passed out of college in 2020.*
- *He is having a doubt in mathematics.*
- *She went to buy vegetables only.*
- *Let us go for a walk in the evening, no?*

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Singlish

- The colloquial English of Singapore
- English, with Malay, Tamil, Hokkien, Cantonese ...
- Not officially endorsed, but central to Singaporean identity

Despite the government's *Speak Good English* campaigns, it thrives in media, humour and everyday talk

Singlish Vocabulary

kiasu	*He is so kiasu.*	afraid to lose out
shiok	*This food is so shiok!*	delicious, enjoyable
blur	*Why are you so blur?*	confused
paiseh	*So paiseh to ask!*	embarrassed
ang moh	*The ang moh loves laksa.*	a Caucasian (“red hair”)

Try our Singlish Dictionary!

Singlish Grammar

aspect by adverb	*He go already.* "He has gone."
particles	*Don't worry lah!* emphasis, assurance
	You want coffee, ah? questioning
	Very expensive, leh. softening, tentative
no article, plural	*I go market. I buy 3 book.*

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Hong Kong English

pronunciation	Cantonese tone shapes stress; /n/ and /l/ merge (*night*, *light*), as in Cantonese 你 *nei5* → *lei5*
grammar	articles and prepositions dropped: *I go market.*
vocabulary	*yum cha* “drink tea”, *char siu* “roast pork”

From British rule (1842–1997); still used in education, business and law. Also *th* as [f] or [t], and simplified final clusters (see Setter et al., 2010, ch. 3)

Hong Kong English Vocabulary

dai pai dong	open-air food stall
si fu	master, skilled worker
cha chaan teng	Hong Kong-style cafe
add oil	keep going! good luck!
long time no see	perhaps 好耐冇見

He very smart, la. I no understand. I go yum cha with family tomorrow.

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Philippine English: The American One

history	American rule 1898–1946; the *Thomasite* teachers from 1901
pronunciation	rhotic, from American English;
	/f/ often [p]: *Pilipino*
vocabulary	*comfort room* “toilet”, *carnap* “steal a car”,
	open the light “switch it on”
use	**Taglish**: mixing Tagalog and English

About 70 million speakers (the second largest in Asia); the only major Asian English from American, not British, colonial rule

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Japanese English

add vowels	*table* → *tēburu*
/l/ = /r/	*light*, *right* sound alike
fewer clusters	*strike* → *sutoraiku*
shorten	*convenience store* → *konbini*

和製英語 *wasei eigo* 'Japanese-made English': English-like words made in Japan

Wasei Eigo

sararīman	salary man	male office worker
ōeru	OL, office lady	female office worker
baikingu	Viking	buffet
mai pēsu	my pace	going at one's own speed
pawahara	power harassment	workplace bullying
sukinshippu	skinship	physical closeness
hātofuru	heartful	warm-hearted, caring

Konglish

핸드폰	*haendeupon*	hand phone: mobile
화이팅	*hwaiting*	fighting: go for it!
아이쇼핑	*aisyoping*	eye shopping: window shopping
셀카	*selka*	self camera: selfie
스킨십	*seukinsip*	skinship: from Japanese

Handphone is also everyday Singapore and Malaysian English; Japanese says 携帯 *keitai* or スマホ *sumaho*

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English as a Lingua Franca

Jenkins (2000)'s **Lingua Franca Core**: what intelligibility needs	
core	consonants (not *th*); aspirated /p t k/; initial clusters; vowel length; nuclear stress
not core	*th*; exact vowel quality; weak forms; word stress

When most English is between non-native speakers, the target is mutual intelligibility, not a native accent: one answer to how we balance intelligibility and diversity

Inner-Circle Variation Explains Asian Englishes

covert prestige	Strine, AAVE, Singlish: in-group solidarity
standard ideology	used against AAVE, UK dialects, Indian English
error or innovation	AAVE rules long called errors; Asian features too
ownership	AAVE in schools $\approx$ teaching Indian English, Singlish

Asian varieties are not special cases: all Englishes are dialects (Milroy and Milroy, 1999)

The Future of Asian Englishes

- Growing **prestige**, in schools and online
- Will codification make **new standards**?
- How do we balance **intelligibility** and **diversity**?

How established a variety is depends on its size and its prestige

Activity: Innovation, Deviation, or Mistake?

In pairs: innovation (accepted in some community), deviation (different from a chosen standard), or mistake (accepted nowhere)?

(1) *Can you prepone the meeting to tomorrow?*

(2) *Yesterday I go market, very crowded, lah.*

(3) *He is knowing the answer.*

(4) *She is 22 years.*

(5) *This food is damn shiok!*

(6) *They knowed the answer.*

(7) *I need to control my homework.*

(8) *I beez in the trap.*

Whose norms are you using when you decide?

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